

When to Use AI and When NOT to Use AI

Use this document to accompany the first introduction video for the "AI Agents for Everyday Professionals" course.

Understanding AI Agents: The Super Smart Intern

Think of AI agents as super smart interns. They can be very intelligent, thorough, and methodical in solving problems. However, if they are not managed and directed appropriately, they may not give you the results you're looking for. Like any intern, AI agents need clear instructions, appropriate oversight, and well-defined tasks to excel.

When TO Use AI Agents

1. Organizing and Analyzing Large Blocks of Text or Messy Information

One of the best use cases for AI agents is taking long blocks of text or messy information and organizing it, analyzing it, and providing you with multiple ways to assess the data for your personal uses.

Examples:

- Analyzing large blocks of customer data from your organization
- Processing huge amounts of emails from your team
- Summarizing information into formats that are easier to synthesize and respond to

Automation Opportunity: You can automate this by creating a summarized report that emails to your inbox once a week, eliminating the need to manually process this information.

2. Low-Stakes Tasks Requiring Nuanced Judgment

AI agents excel when you have action items that are relatively low-stakes but still require some level of nuanced judgment.

Customer Support Prioritization Example:

Imagine you have a huge volume of customer support messages. An AI agent can:

- Prioritize which messages are most urgent and require quick responses
- Deprioritize messages that are trivial and could receive automated responses
- Apply consistent judgment across hundreds or thousands of messages

3. Pattern Recognition in Large Data Sets

AI agents can spot nuanced patterns in large data sets that might take you hours to find if you were manually sifting through the data on your own.

Example Application: Analyzing trends, anomalies, or correlations across thousands of data points quickly and efficiently.

4. Personalized Mass Communications

AI agents can help you send targeted, personalized communications at scale.

Sales Outreach Example:

If you want to send mass emails to different leads for your organization, you can:

- Use AI agents to scrape and analyze data about potential buyers
- Send targeted messages based on specific information discovered
- Make mass communications feel more personalized and relevant

When NOT to Use AI Agents

While AI agents can be powerful tools, there are specific situations where using them is unwise or potentially harmful. Understanding these limitations is just as important as knowing their capabilities.

1. High-Stakes Decisions (Especially Financial)

Never use AI agents for high-stakes decisions like financial decisions at your organization. The underlying AI tools that these agents rely on still have a tendency to hallucinate. Using AI agents for critical financial decisions would add and compound risk to your organization.

Why This Matters: Even small errors in high-stakes contexts can have massive consequences. AI hallucinations in financial contexts could lead to incorrect budgeting, flawed investment decisions, or compliance violations.

2. Sensitive Data Processing

Be extremely careful about using AI agents for anything involving sensitive data, such as:

- People's personal financial information
- Medical records
- Any data that could be compromised in a security breach

You don't want to give third-party AI agent tools access to this type of information, even though recent iterations of agent tools have become more secure than their predecessors.

Best Practice for Data Protection:

For any spreadsheets or other organizational data you're uploading to an AI agent tool, always remove people's names and anything that could be used to identify them. You never know where that data might end up, especially depending on the terms of service of different tools.

3. Simple Tasks Where AI Adds Unnecessary Complexity

Don't use AI agent workflows when they add unnecessary complication. There are many times when adding an AI agent workflow would create more work than it saves.

Example: If you just need to send a one-sentence email to someone quickly, it's probably more efficient to:

- Think of the email yourself
- Type it up quickly
- Send it immediately

Rather than building out a whole workflow that you'd need to oversee, potentially correct, and maintain. In these cases, the AI workflow won't be the best decision.

Decision Framework: Should You Use an AI Agent?

Before implementing an AI agent workflow, ask yourself these questions:

Questions to Ask:

- ✓ Is this a repetitive task that happens regularly?
- ✓ Does this task involve processing large amounts of information?
- ✓ Would errors in this task be relatively low-stakes?
- ✓ Would automation save significant time over doing this manually?
- ✓ Is the data involved non-sensitive or can identifying information be removed?

- ✗ Is this a high-stakes decision with serious consequences for errors?
- ✗ Does this involve sensitive personal or financial information?
- ✗ Is this a one-time or very infrequent task?
- ✗ Would it be faster to just do this task manually?
- ✗ Does this require human empathy, creativity, or strategic judgment?

If you answered yes to most of the green checkmark questions and no to most of the orange warning questions, you likely have a good candidate for AI agent automation.

Key Principles to Remember

1. AI Agents Are Like Super Smart Interns

They're intelligent and capable but need proper direction and oversight to deliver quality results.

2. Best for Processing and Organizing

AI agents excel at taking messy information and making it structured, searchable, and actionable.

3. Avoid High-Stakes Decisions

Never rely on AI agents for decisions where errors could have serious financial, legal, or safety consequences.

4. Protect Sensitive Data

Always remove identifying information before uploading data to AI agent tools, regardless of security promises.

5. Keep It Simple When Appropriate

If a task takes 30 seconds to do manually, don't spend an hour building an AI workflow for it.

6. Automation Should Save Time, Not Create Work

The best use cases are tasks that are repetitive, time-consuming, and relatively low-stakes.

Moving Forward

Once you're clear on the specific tasks you want to use AI agent tools to automate, they can be genuinely exciting and transformative tools for your workflow. The key is being thoughtful and strategic about when and how you deploy them.

As you continue through this course, you'll learn the technical skills to build these workflows. Keep referring back to these principles to ensure you're applying AI agents in situations where they'll provide the most value with the least risk.